and his charismatic spouse, Soong Mei-Ling (known as Madame Chiang), when he visited Chongqing in August 1939. Nehru wrote about this visit: 'I returned to India an even greater admirer of China and the Chinese people than I had been previously.' [2] When Chiang Kai-shek visited India in early February 1942 and met Nehru, he urged the latter to moderate the INC's antipathy to British rule in India. He desperately needed British help, especially critical war supplies, from over the 'Hump'—which was the name for the air route from British India to China over the Himalayas—and felt that the INC's harsh stand against British rule might upset these plans. As a gesture to Nehru, Chiang Kai-shek voiced his support for the cause of self-determination for India after the war. Nehru grew even more firm in his conviction that the two countries would play a significant part in the post-war world order. [3]

Like Nehru, Mao too was greatly interested in international affairs. Even as the Soviet Red Army was preparing to attack Berlin, Mao Zedong was defining the Chinese Communist Party's foreign policy for the post-war world in a document titled 'On Coalition Government' in April 1945. Declaring that the moment was near when the Japanese would be decisively defeated, Mao said that it was China that had led the anti-Japanese war in the Asian mainland, and 'they will also play a very great role in safeguarding peace in the post-war world and the decisive one in safeguarding peace in the East'. In a longish chapter on foreign policy, Mao exhorted the international community to respect China and cautioned the Americans that they were 'committing a gross mistake' by supporting President Chiang Kai-shek. Mao was sympathetic to the freedom struggle of other Asian countries. He referred specifically to India, saying, 'We hope that India will attain independence. For an independent and democratic India is not only needed by the Indian people but is essential for world peace.' However, unlike